was formed in Rajasthan with the aim of ushering in ‘Ram’s rule’ by Swami Kalpatri in 1947).[93] Mookerjee, who had quit the Hindu Mahasabha earlier, emphasised that the new party had no connection with the Mahasabha.

Yet, it was the Jan Sangh’s close relationship with the RSS, which supported it but was not a political party, that raised questions from the very beginning. Mookerjee addressed this issue directly in his inaugural speech to the party, acknowledging the RSS lineage of several members. He said emphatically, ‘There are members of the RSS who in their individual capacity, have come in to the Jana Sangh and are working on it. But there are also large numbers of other people in the party who have nothing to do with the RSS.’[94]

Mookerjee and RSS chief Golwalkar had even met to discuss the contours of this relationship prior to the party’s formation. Golwalkar later recalled this conversation in a 1956 article, saying ‘we [he and Mookerjee] met often’. He added that in these conversations he had insisted that ‘RSS could not be drawn into politics’, would not ‘play second fiddle to any political or other party’ and would not be a ‘handmaiden to political parties’.[95]

Yet, in practice, while the early Jan Sangh relied on Mookerjee’s national stature as a Hindu traditionalist, to a large extent it was built on the strength of the RSS cadre. Most of its ‘key organisers came from the RSS’. These included Deendayal Upadhyaya, secretary of the UP Jan Sangh; Atal Bihari Vajpayee, all-India general secretary who had joined the RSS in his student days; Professor Mahavir; and Balraj Madhok, founder of the Punjab Jan Sangh and an RSS pracharak from Jammu.[96]

This meant that when Mookerjee died in 1953, the nascent party was engulfed in a major leadership tussle: between the more liberal Hindu traditionalists who had come with him and those who came from the RSS. Between 1951 and 1967, the party had twelve presidents, with an average tenure of 1.3 years each (see Table 8.4). The organisation only gained leadership stability from 1967 onwards: first with Deendayal Upadhyaya, then with Atal Bihari Vajpayee and later with L.K. Advani. The latter two served as party president for four years each until the Jan Sangh merged into the Janata Party in 1977. All three men had been in the RSS.